FIVE

December 1978

‘Okay, that’s enough. Get out of there now, or Babaji will scold you,’ Maa chided Dada and me as we played in the ankle-length water at the entrance of the Golden Temple in Amritsar. A turbaned saint, dressed in dark-blue overalls, stared at us with a smile behind his thick beard. He stood at attention, guarding the entrance with a traditional spear in his hand. It didn’t matter to us if the water was freezing cold. We were enjoying ourselves. It was a bright sunny Sunday in the peak of winter and Papaji had planned to take us out. He had been posted to Amritsar recently. The Golden Temple was not very far from the cantonment, and all four of us loved going there. Where Maa and Papaji found peace in the serenity of the soothing Gurbani that echoed on the premises, Dada and I loved to play in its vast marble corridors and enjoyed feeding ‘kadah prasad’ to the fish in the holy pond. Although Papaji was an atheist, something about the Golden Temple drew him to it.

‘Only if you promise to take us for langar,’ I had negotiated with Maa and she had nodded in approval. Dada and I trotted carelessly ahead of Maa and Papaji, barefoot on the cold marble. ‘Keep your heads covered with the rumala, both of you,’ Maa’s instruction followed us as we made for the stairs. From the arched entrance, the first thing that came into view was the